

from service with the galley fleet of the Knights of St John in Malta, where many French gentlemen had gained naval experience. A path for the sons of the well-born to enter naval service was opened by the creation of the Garde de Marine, training them to become commissioned officers. The structure of French society required senior commanders to be noble, but merit was usually rewarded. Abraham Duquesne had been born into a Dieppe merchant family, but was ennobled so that he could hold a high command. French officers' seamanship was not always faultless – Admiral Jean d'Estrées lost an entire fleet through bad navigation, running onto rocks in the West Indies in 1678 – but they usually showed a high level of courage and fighting spirit.



Abraham Duquesne
One of Louis XIV's most able naval commanders, Duquesne won significant victories over the Spanish and Dutch in the Mediterranean. His Protestant faith prevented him from reaching the rank of full admiral.

TEST OF BATTLE

The Sun King's fleet was blooded as an ally of the English in the Third Anglo-Dutch War of 1672–74. It fought the Dutch and Spanish in the Mediterranean, and then took on the English and Dutch together in the War of the League of Augsburg from 1689. The English and Dutch were ill-prepared for this conflict and at first the French scored notable successes. An army was landed in Ireland and victory at Beachy Head in 1690 gave France temporary command of the sea. Yet a major war soon put the structure that Colbert had created under severe strain. Orderly conscription failed to deliver sufficient sailors and soon press-gangs were in action, although ships still remained undermanned. As France was both a Mediterranean and an Atlantic power, concentrating all its naval forces to fight for control of the English Channel proved impossible. A major defeat at the twin battles of Barfleur and La Hogue in 1692 convinced Louis that major fleet engagements were a costly and fruitless indulgence.

COMMERCE RAIDING

Renouncing the struggle for command of the sea, the king ordered his sailors to focus on commerce raiding. They did so very successfully, with bold captains such as René Duguay-Trouin from St Malo and Jean Bart from Dunkirk sailing at the head of small hunting packs. By the time the war ended in 1697 some 4,000 English and Dutch ships had been captured, including the immensely valuable Smyrna convoy ambushed by the French Mediterranean fleet in 1693. When fighting resumed in 1702, in the War of the Spanish Succession, French commerce raiding was again effective, but there was no disguising the overall decline of the French navy. Increasingly short of money, Louis was reduced to fitting out fleets of privateers by sharing the cost and the profits with wealthy businessmen. In truth, as a continental land power, France logically had to give priority to its army in the allocation of resources. Colbert's vision of France as the hub of a maritime trading empire was never more than partially realized.

1619–1683

JEAN-BAPTISTE COLBERT

FRENCH MINISTER OF FINANCE AND THE NAVY

Born in Reims, eastern France, Colbert learned his trade as an administrator in the service of Cardinal Mazarin, the effective ruler of France during the minority of Louis XIV. Soon after Louis took power into his own hands in 1661, Colbert was appointed Intendant of Finance, in control of taxation, trade, and manufactures. Two years later he was also styled Intendant of the Navy. Colbert saw that a strong navy was essential to protect maritime trade and to enable France to expand its empire. His financial reforms vastly increased tax revenues, making funds available for the building of ships and naval facilities. In his later years Colbert was unpopular, blamed for the high taxation that financed Louis' wars. He never convinced the king of the overriding importance of naval power and overseas trade. Yet by 1683, when he died, the French navy was the largest in Europe, with 117 ships of the line, 1,200 officers, and over 50,000 men.

